

— WEEKLY BULLETIN —

SHABBAT NITZAVIM–VAYEILECH

4–5 September 2026 · 22–23 Elul 5786

SHABBAT TIMES FOR POUGHKEEPSIE, NY (41.70° N, 73.92° W)

CANDLE LIGHTING7:06 pm

Erev Shabbat, Friday, 4 September · 18 minutes to sunset

SUNSET7:24 pm

Erev Shabbat, Friday, 4 September

HABDALA7:59 pm

Saturday, 5 September · end of Shabbat



TORAH READING & HAFTARAH

Nitzavim–Vayeilech, Deuteronomy 29:9–31:30.

Moses gathers everyone before the Eternal: leaders and elders, women and children, the stranger in the camp, the one who cuts the wood and the one who draws the water. The covenant includes those standing there and those not there that day. He speaks of exile and of return, and promises that a heart turned back will be gathered from the far ends of the sky. The commandment is not in the heavens and not across the sea. Life and blessing are set out plainly, and Israel is told to choose life. Then Moses, at a hundred and twenty, hands the work to Joshua, writes the Torah down, and teaches the song that will stand as a witness.

Haftarah: Isaiah 61:10–63:9. Ashkenazim and Sephardim read the same passage.

The last of the seven consolations before Rosh Hashana. Isaiah rejoices in garments of salvation, dressed like a bride and bridegroom on the day itself. For Zion's sake the prophet will not keep silent until her vindication shines out like a torch and she is given a new name. Watchmen are posted on the walls and told to give the Holy One no rest. A figure comes up from Edom in crimsoned garments, having trodden the winepress alone. The passage closes with the kindnesses of the Eternal recalled aloud: in all their trouble there was trouble, and they were lifted and carried all their days.

IN THE WEEK AHEAD

Saturday, 5 September — Leil Selihot for Ashkenazim; Sephardim have been saying Selihot since 2 Elul.

Friday, 11 September — Erev Rosh Hashana. Candle lighting 6:54 pm (18 minutes to sunset); sunset 7:12 pm.

Saturday, 12 September — Rosh Hashana.

KIDDUSH

Kiddush follows the service. Meals are dairy and vegetarian.

We meet in a private home; our address is shared by message. If prayer is not your thing, you are welcome to join only for the Kiddush and the company.

To RSVP and to register food issues and avoidances, kindly contact the Congregation's secretary at kehillatzikhronzvi@gmail.com by Thursday night at 10:00 pm

REFLECTIONS ON THE PARASHA

HALAKHA

Elul is nearly gone, and the Rambam records what these days look like in a congregation: everyone rises while it is still night and prays in the synagogues with words that break the heart, until daybreak.¹ He also rules that repentance and calling out are welcome at every hour of the year, and that in the days near Rosh Hashana they are welcomed more readily still; a community that turns with a whole heart is answered at once.² Selihot are that rising put into words. The hour is early, the room is dark, and the prayer is public.

The Sephardic custom is to rise in the last watch of the night from Rosh Hodesh Elul until Kippur, while Ashkenazim begin on the Sunday before Rosh Hashana, and a week earlier when Rosh Hashana falls early in the week.³ London and Amsterdam long said Selihot in the evening, before Kadish Titkabbal, since few could rise before dawn in these cold countries and more people came to the synagogue at minha and arbit; the Hida objected sharply, holding that the Thirteen Attributes belong to an hour of favour.⁴ The Attributes wait for a minyan. Ours is made of women and men, counted alike.

1. Mishneh Torah, Repentance 3:4 2. Mishneh Torah, Repentance 2:6 3. Keter Shem Tob, vol. 6, p. 8 4. Keter Shem Tob, vol. 2, pp. 711–712

AGGADA

The Ramban takes “this commandment” in Moses' mouth to be teshuvah itself. Nothing about it is hard or far off. It can be done at any time and in any place: the mouth confesses, the heart turns.¹ The midrash makes the same point as a question. They asked Moses: you tell us it is not in the heavens and not across the sea; then where is it? He answered, in a place that is near.² Moses gives no address for it beyond the mouth and the heart. In the week before Rosh Hashana that is close enough to reach.

1. Ramban on Deuteronomy 30:11 2. Devarim Rabbah 8:6



Torah readings and calendar data by [Hebcad.com](https://hebcad.com) (CC BY 4.0). Times are computed for Poughkeepsie by the congregation's luach; the end of Shabbat follows the convention of Congregation Shearith Israel, New York.

